

Charles Garnier and Henri Labrouste

Charles Garnier (1825–98) studied in Rome in 1848 and absorbed the Byzantine style of Turkey and Greece. He also studied with the neoclassical architect L.H. Lebas (1782–1867) and worked briefly with Viollet-le-Duc. Garnier mixed industrial structural materials with flamboyant but controlled décor to produce such glamorous buildings as the Paris Opéra and the Monte-Carlo Casino in Monaco (opposite), which epitomize the Second Empire under Napoleon III (1852–70).

Henri Labrouste (1801–75) was a leading architect of 19th-century France. On leaving the École des Beaux-Arts, he spent six years in Rome (1825–30). One of the first architects to use iron-frame construction, he also believed that architecture should reflect society. His Bibliothèque Sainte-Geneviève in Paris (1843–50) sensitively exposes iron structural elements of columns and arches, while his reading room of the Bibliothèque Nationale (1860–7) comprises nine decorated metal domes supported by slim cast-iron columns.

